

Spicy tofu pineapple rice salad

This dish has a brilliant flavor and look to it. It can be served as a side dish, an entree, or a salad among many in a buffet. The pineapple and dark rice make an excellent combination.

½ cup Lundberg Japonica rice blend [100g]*

1 cup finely chopped fresh pineapple
(a chunky mush) [180g]

5 tablespoons vegetable oil

1 tablespoon molasses

1 tablespoon unrefined cane sugar

2 teaspoons tomato paste

2 teaspoons balsamic vinegar

1 teaspoon tamarind paste

1 teaspoon chipotle chile powder

2 garlic cloves, minced

½ teaspoon salt

Freshly ground pepper

1 pound extra-firm tofu, pressed to remove
excess water and sliced lengthwise in half
[500g]

1 small onion, minced

1 carrot, thinly sliced on the diagonal

1 yellow bell pepper, cut into ½-inch [1-cm]
squares

4 scallions, thinly sliced

¼ cup coarsely chopped cilantro [60ml]

1. **Cook** the rice as directed on the package. Meanwhile, in a medium bowl, mix half of the pineapple with 1 tablespoon of the vegetable oil, the molasses, sugar, tomato paste, vinegar, tamarind paste, chile powder, garlic, salt, and a light grinding of pepper. Set the marinade aside.
2. Heat the remaining oil in a large skillet over medium-high heat. When very hot and almost shimmering, **add** the tofu and fry, turning once, until lightly browned and crisp on both sides, 3 to 5 minutes. Drain on paper towels. As soon as the tofu is cool

*Lundberg brand sells a combination rice that includes a short-grain black and a medium-grain mahogany. If you can't find this, look for other interesting dark rice, either packaged or in the bulk section.

enough to handle, cut it into $\frac{3}{4}$ -inch [2-cm] cubes. Add to the marinade and stir gently to coat.

3. **Pour** out all but 1 tablespoon or so of the oil from the skillet. Add the onion and cook over medium heat until softened and lightly browned, about 5 minutes. Add the carrot and yellow bell pepper and cook for another 2 or 3 minutes, until the vegetables are slightly softened. Add the scallions and cook for another 30 seconds, stirring frequently. Turn into a large bowl.
4. Pour the tofu with all its marinade into the skillet. (Use a rubber spatula to scrape all the marinade out of the bowl.) **Cook** over high heat, stirring constantly, until the marinade is completely absorbed and the tofu is nicely browned.
5. Add the tofu, cooked rice, remaining fresh pineapple, and the cilantro to the vegetables in the bowl. **Toss** to mix well. Season with additional salt and pepper to taste. Serve warm or at room temperature.

SERVES 4 TO 6

